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THE PRINCIPALITIES OF CHERNIGOV AND NOVGOROD-SEVERSK

Desna-Seym River Towns, the Olgovichi Realm and the Steppe Frontier

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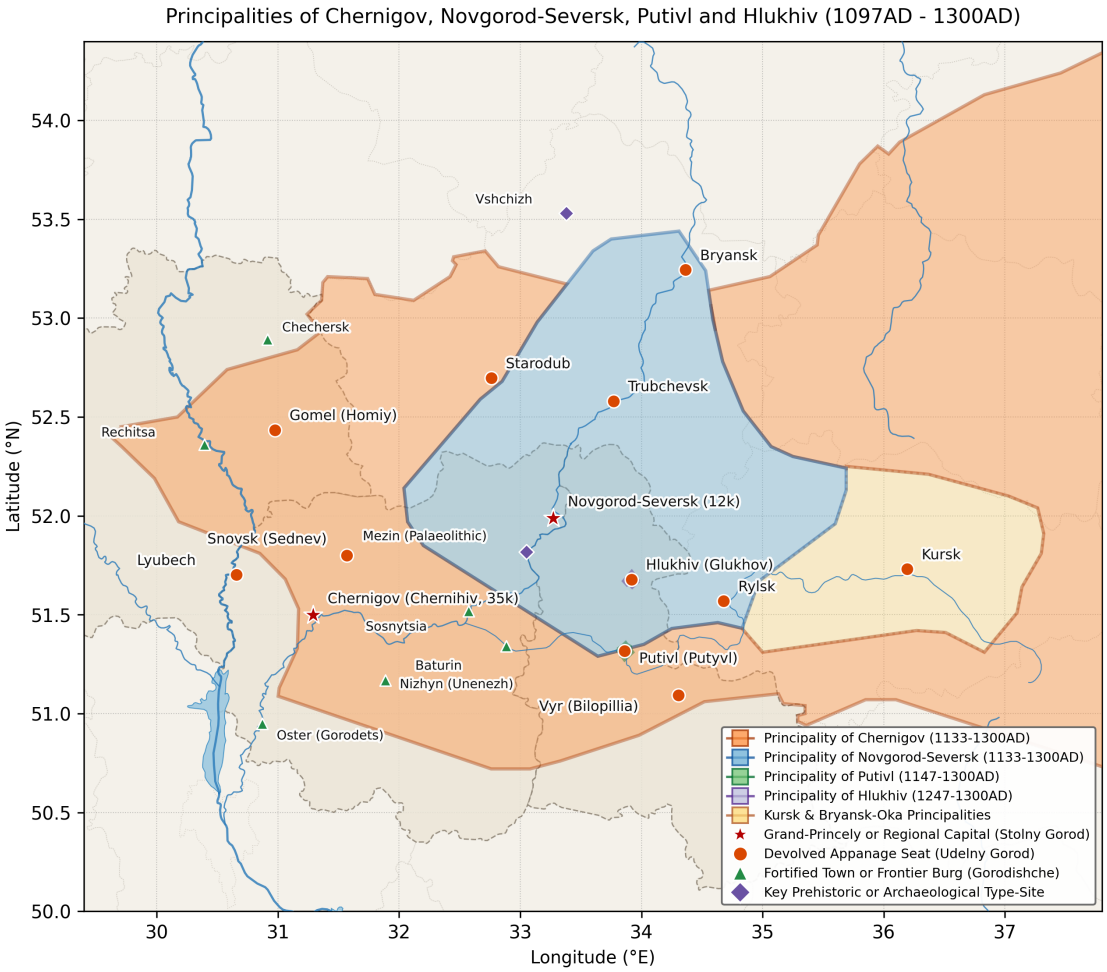


Figure 1. Approximate boundaries of the southern Chernigov-Seversk principalities (72,24k km^2), showing the Olgovichi capital at Chernigov (35k in 1200AD), the Seversk seats at Novgorod-Seversk (12k) and Putivl (7,5k), the post-Mongol refuge at Hlukhiv and the Dnieper-Sozh river towns.

Abstract

From the eleventh to the thirteenth centuries, the Olgovichi branch of the Rurikid dynasty ruled the largest territorial domain in Eastern Europe, stretching from the Dnieper, Desna and Sozh river junctions in the south-west to the Upper Oka, the Moscow river approaches and the Kursk Posemye in the north-east [1][2][3]. To avoid double-counting across regional boundaries, the wider Chernigov-Seversk realm is divided along modern frontiers into two complementary zones. The Southern Core of Chernigov

and Novgorod-Seversk (72,24k km^2) covers the dynastic capitals and forest-steppe heartland across Chernihivska Oblast (Ukraine, 31,9k km^2), Sumska Oblast (Ukraine, 23,83k km^2) and the Eastern Gomel and Lower Sozh-Dnieper Corridor (Belarus, 16,5k km^2). This area encompasses the primary domains of the principalities of Chernigov, Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl, Vorgol and post-Mongol Hlukhiv. The Northern Russian Half (~118k km^2), accounted for separately in the European Russia review, covers the northern forest and north-eastern forest-steppe appanages inside the modern Russian Federation across the Upper Oka and Bryansk-Chernigov North (including Bryansk, Starodub, Trubchevsk, Vshchizh, Karachev, Novosil, Tarusa and Kozelsk) and the Kursk-Seversk Steppe Frontier (Kursk, Rylsk and Yelets).

In the Southern Core, human settlement began in the Upper Palaeolithic mammoth-hunting camps of the middle Desna gorge (4,5k inhabitants at 10000BC) and grew through the Early Iron Age hillfort cultures (85k at 500BC) and the Roman-era Kiev and Chernyakhov horizons (140k at 300AD). After the eighth- and ninth-century Slavic expansion of the Severians and Radimichi (220k by 900AD) and their incorporation into Kievan Rus (280k by 1000AD), the Southern Core reached a pre-Mongol peak of 460k inhabitants in 1200AD (360k - 560k, mean density 6,37 inh/km^2). Almost a fifth of this population lived in fortified towns, led by the capital of Chernigov (35k inhabitants across 330 ha) and the princely seats of Novgorod-Seversk (12k), Putivl (7,5k), Gomel (5k) and Hlukhiv (5k) [4][5][6]. Combined with the 500k inhabitants of the Northern Russian Half (210k in Bryansk-Starodub-Upper Oka and 290k in the Kursk-Rylsk Posemye), the Grand Principality of Chernigov-Seversk contained 960k people in 1200AD, a total rivalled in Rus only by the Kievan and Galician-Volhynian south [7]. Mengu-Timur's campaign of October 1239 shattered the exposed Desna and Seym towns, cutting the population of the Southern Core by more than half to 210k in 1250AD before partial recovery in the wooded country around Hlukhiv, Putivl and northern Chernigov brought numbers back to 260k by 1300AD.

Date	Population	Range	Density (inh/km^2)	Urban Share (%)	Historical Notes
10000BC	4,5k	2,5k - 7,5k	0,06	0%	Mezin, Pushkari I & Chulatovo mammoth-bone camps
6000BC	9k	5,5k - 14k	0,12	0%	Desna-Sozh Mesolithic & early Pit-Comb Ware sites
4000BC	18k	11k - 27k	0,25	0%	Dnieper-Donets II & Desna Neolithic fishers
1500BC	52k	34k - 74k	0,72	0%	Sosnytsia & Marianivka Bronze Age agro-pastoralists
500BC	85k	55k - 120k	1,18	0%	Yukhnovo, Milograd & Scythian Posemye hillforts
0AD	105k	70k - 145k	1,45	0%	Late Zarubintsy (Pochep-Harivka) & Late Scythian
300AD	140k	95k - 190k	1,94	0%	Kiev culture (Roishche) & northern Chernyakhov peak
500AD	115k	75k - 160k	1,59	0%	Kolochin culture forest-riverine settlements
700AD	165k	115k - 220k	2,28	2,5%	Volyntsevo & early Romny-Borshchevo Severian opoliya
800AD	190k	135k - 250k	2,63	4,8%	Bititsa, Gornal & Romny fortified Severian hillforts

900AD	220k	160k - 285k	3,05	8,5%	Shestovytsia, Chernigov barrows & Lyubech trade axis
1000AD	280k	210k - 355k	3,88	13,2%	Early Rurikid tribute network & Severian integration
1100AD	365k	285k - 450k	5,05	17,8%	Post-1097AD Lyubech Congress Olgovichi expansion
1200AD	460k	360k - 560k	6,37	21,5%	Olgovichi apogee (116 hillforts; Chernigov 35k)
1250AD	210k	155k - 275k	2,91	10,5%	October 1239AD Mongol destruction of Desna-Posemye
1300AD	260k	195k - 330k	3,6	11,8%	Post-Mongol Hlukhiv, Putivl & Chernigov principalities

Table 1. Estimated population, uncertainty ranges, settlement density and urban share across the Desna, Seym, Snov and Lower Sozh basins (72,24k km^2) from the Late Palaeolithic mammoth-hunting camps of the middle Desna gorge (10000BC) to the post-Mongol principalities (1300AD).

Background

The political geography of the Left-Bank Desna, Seym, Snov and Lower Sozh basin reflects the dynastic division of the Olgovichi (descendants of Oleg Svyatoslavich, d. 1115AD, who secured hereditary rights to the Chernigov land at the Congress of Lyubech in 1097AD) [2][3]. Following Vsevolod Olgovich's accession to the Kievan throne (1139AD), the realm divided into the senior Chernigov patrimony (*Otchina*) along the Lower and Middle Desna, Snov and Sozh, and the junior Seversk (*Sever*) patrimony along the Middle Desna and Seym. After the Mongol sack of 1239AD and the execution of Grand Prince Mikhail Vsevolodovich at the Golden Horde (1246AD), the southern lands reorganised into the post-Mongol principalities of Chernigov, Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl and Hlukhiv (founded 1247AD). Table 2 lists the principalities within the Southern Core territory.

Dynastic Phase	Principality Name	Active Span	Capital (Coords)	Core Basin & Administrative Coverage
Senior Patrimony	Principality of Chernigov	1133-1279AD	Chernigov (51,5°N, 31,29°E)	Lower & Middle Desna, Snov, Oster & Lower Sozh (Chernihiv & Gomel)
Post-Mongol Core	Principality of Chernigov	1279-1356AD	Chernigov (51,5°N, 31,29°E)	Post-Mongol Desna-Snov-Sozh core under Bryansk-Chernigov line

Late Appanage	Principality of Chernigov	1356-1358AD	Chernigov (51,5°N, 31,29°E)	Late post-Mongol Chernigov domain prior to Lithuanian annexation
Seversk Patrimony	Principality of Novgorod-Seversk	1133-1363AD	Novgorod-Seversk (51,99°N, 33,27°E)	Middle Desna, Lower Seym & Ivot-Esman (NE Chernihiv & N Sumy)
Posemye Appanage	Principality of Putivl	1147-1501AD	Putivl (51,32°N, 33,86°E)	Middle Seym (Posemye), Vyr, Kleven & Upper Sula & Psyol (Sumy)
Kleven Appanage	Principality of Vorgol	1203-1241AD	Vorgol (51,48°N, 33,78°E)	Kleven-Seym interfluve NW of Putivl (Krolevets & Putyvl)
Esman-Kleven Refuge	Principality of Hlukhiv	1247-1408AD	Hlukhiv (51,68°N, 33,92°E)	Post-Mongol Esman-Kleven plateau (Hlukhiv & Yampil)

Table 2. Dynastic divisions, seats and river-basin boundaries of the Olgovichi principalities in the southern Chernigov-Seversk core from the post-Lyubech partition (1133AD) to the Lithuanian annexation.

Methodology

Because historical and archaeological studies by A. K. Zaitsev [1], V. P. Kovalenko [4], A. V. Kuza [6][8] and M. Dimnik [3] often cite aggregate figures for the entire Chernigov-Seversk realm from the Desna mouth to the Upper Oka and Kursk Posemye, separate accounting is needed to link this Southern Core study with the Northern Russian appanages documented in the European Russia regional review.

In the northern and north-eastern wings of the Olgovichi patrimony, the Upper Oka and Bryansk-Chernigov North (~70k km^2) covers modern Bryansk, Kaluga, Orel and western Tula Oblasts, comprising Bryansk, Starodub, Trubchevsk, Vshchizh, Karachev, Novosil, Tarusa, Mtsensk, Odoev, Vorotynsk, Belyov and Kozelsk. Following the 1239AD sack of southern Chernigov, Prince Roman Mikhailovich transferred the senior Chernigov-Bryansk throne northward into the Bryansk forest (*Debryansk*), initiating a lasting population shift toward the wooded Upper Oka (*Verchovskie*) principalities. To the south-east, the Kursk-Seversk Steppe Frontier (~48k km^2) covers modern Kursk and western Lipetsk and Belgorod Oblasts, comprising Kursk, Rylsk and Yelets along the Tuskar, Upper Seym, Svapa and Upper Psyol rivers.

Table 3 shows how the four southern districts of the Southern Core (Chernigov Core, Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl-Vorgol-Hlukhiv and Lower Sozh and Gomel) combine with the northern Upper Oka and Kursk-Rylsk appanages to reconstruct the population of the wider Chernigov-Seversk lands (800AD - 1300AD) without boundary overlap.

Principality / District	800AD	1000AD	1100AD	1200AD	1250AD	1300AD
Chernigov Core (Desna-Snov-Oster)	100k	150k	195k	240k	100k	130k

Novgorod-Seversk (Middle Desna)	30k	42k	55k	70k	35k	42k
Putivl, Vorgol & Hlukhiv (Posemye)	26k	38k	50k	70k	35k	38k
Lower Sozh & Dnieper (Gomel Corridor)	34k	50k	65k	80k	40k	50k
Southern Core Subtotal (72,24k km^2)	190k	280k	365k	460k	210k	260k
Bryansk, Starodub & Upper Oka North	90k	130k	170k	210k	120k	140k
Kursk & Rylsk Posemye East	100k	150k	200k	290k	100k	120k
Northern Appanages Subtotal (118k km^2)	190k	280k	370k	500k	220k	260k
Grand Principality of Chernigov-Seversk Total	380k	560k	735k	960k	430k	520k

Table 3. Sub-regional population estimates for the four southern districts (72,24k km^2) alongside the northern Bryansk-Upper Oka and Kursk-Rylsk appanages (118k km^2) accounted for in European Russia, showing the 1200AD peak of 960k across the wider Chernigov-Seversk realm and the 54,3% decline in the Southern Core after the October 1239AD campaign.

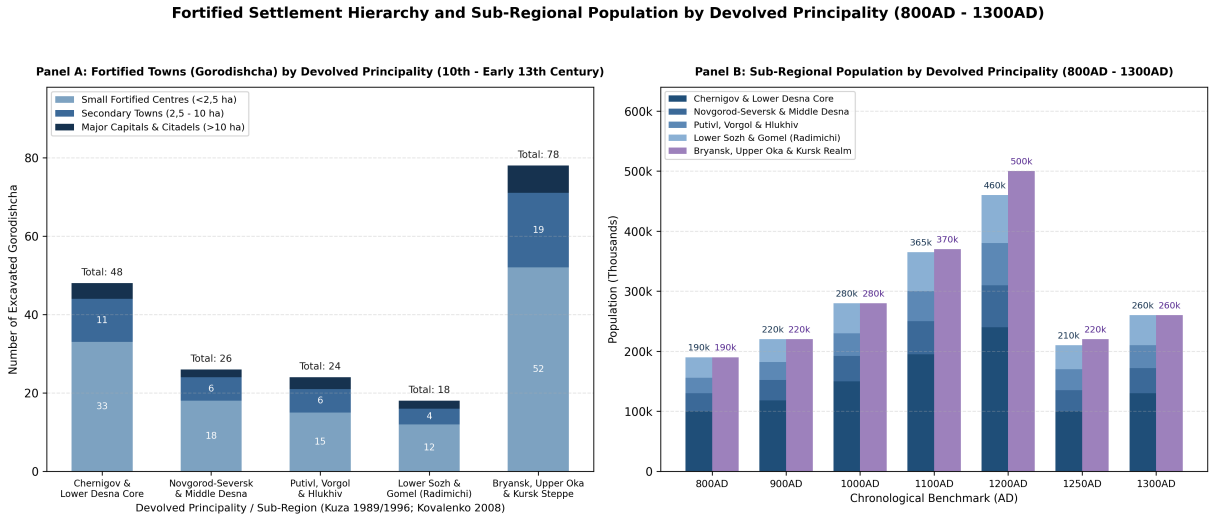


Figure 2. Left: distribution of the 116 excavated fortified settlements (gorodishcha) across the four southern Chernigov-Seversk districts and 78 in the northern Russian appanages, distinguishing major princely capitals (>20 ha), secondary volost centres (5 - 20 ha) and small border forts (<5 ha). Right: sub-regional population trajectories from the Severian-Radimichi tribal era (800AD) through the 1200AD Olgovichi peak to the post-1239AD shift toward Bryansk and Hlukhiv.

Results

Prehistoric and Early Slavic Settlement

Upper Palaeolithic to Bronze Age

The middle Desna chalk gorge between Pushkari, Novgorod-Seversk and Mezin (Mizyn) formed one of the main Upper Palaeolithic Ice Age hunting grounds in Eurasia [9][10][11]. At Mezin (51,83°N, 33,08°E), I. G. Shovkoplyas excavated five circular mammoth-bone *yaranga*-type dwellings enclosing hearths fuelled by bone ash, marine amber ornaments transported over 600 km and geometric meander-engraved ivory bracelets dated to the late Pleniglacial and Bølling-Allerød transition (13000BC - 10000BC). Directly upstream along the Desna bluffs, Pushkari I (Pogon), Chulatovo I-II, Buzhany and the Novgorod-Seversky rock-shelter document multi-family winter aggregation camps of 60 to 120 inhabitants each. Across the 72,24k km^2 regional core, the 10000BC Late Palaeolithic population is estimated at 4,5k inhabitants (2,5k - 7,5k, 0,06 inh/km^2).

During the Holocene climatic optimum (6000BC - 3000BC), Mesolithic hunter-fishers of the Desna-Sozh tradition gave way to the Dnieper-Donets II and Pit-Comb Ware Neolithic cultures, occupying low sandy river terraces along the Desna, Snov, Seym and Sozh (9k inhabitants at 6000BC, rising to 18k by 4000BC). In the Middle and Late Bronze Age (2000BC - 1000BC), the Sosnytsia variant of the Trzciniec-Komariv complex and the Marianivka culture along the Seym introduced mixed millet-barley cultivation and floodplain cattle pastoralism, raising the regional population to 52k at 1500BC (0,72 inh/km^2) [12].

Yukhnovo, Milograd, Kiev and Kolochin Horizons

In the Early Iron Age (700BC - 200BC), the region was divided between two fortified hillfort cultures that built chains of cliff-top forts along the Desna and Sozh [12][13]. The Yukhnovo Culture (named after the Yukhnovo type-hillfort near Novgorod-Seversk) occupied the Middle Desna and Seym valleys, constructing timber-laced earthen ramparts on high right-bank chalk headlands (0,5 - 2,5 ha per hillfort, housing 60 - 150 inhabitants at sites such as Kurove-Yukhnovo, Khorobor, Ponornytsia and Novgorod-Seversk). To the west, the Milograd Culture (named after the Milograd hillfort on the Dnieper south of Rechitsa) occupied the Lower Sozh, Braginka and Dnieper-Desna interfluve (Gomel, Khalch, Milograd, Lyubech and Gorval), while Scythian forest-steppe farmers fortified the Upper Sula, Psyol and Vorskla valleys (Vovkivtsi, Pustoviitivka, Kuzemyn and Romny). By 500BC, regional population reached 85k (1,18 inh/km^2).

During the Late La Tène and Roman Iron Age (200BC - 400AD), Late Zarubintsy (Pochep-Harivka horizon, 105k at 0AD) and Kiev culture (200AD - 450AD, excavated at Roishche, Desna-Harivka and Ulianyky) unfortified riverside hamlets spread along the Desna, Snov and Lower Sozh, while the northernmost Chernyakhov culture settlements reached the Sula, Psyol and southern Seym, supporting a Roman-era peak of 140k inhabitants at 300AD (1,94 inh/km^2) [14][15]. Following the Hunnic collapse of the Chernyakhov frontier in the late fourth century, the early Slavic Kolochin culture (450AD - 700AD, named after the Kolochin I promontory hillfort near Rechitsa) consolidated along the wooded Dnieper-Sozh-Desna valleys, supporting 115k inhabitants at 500AD (1,59 inh/km^2) [15][16].

Severian Expansion and Shestovytsia

In the eighth and ninth centuries, Slavic population growth accelerated under the Volyntsevo culture (700AD - 820AD, named after the type-site near Putivl, alongside the fortified Khazar-Severian administrative citadel at Bytytsia on the Psyol) and its successor, the Romny-Borshchevo culture (800AD - 1000AD, named after the *Monastyryshche* hillfort at Romny on the Sula) [13][17][18]. Identified with the chronicle Severians (*Severyane*) on the Desna, Seym and Sula and the southern Radimichi on the Lower

Sozh, the Romny population combined fortified promontory refuges (Novotroitske, Gornal, Putivl, Vyr, Romny, Chernigov, Snovsk and Gomel) with dense clusters of open *selyshcha* equipped with sunken-featured dwellings (*poluzemlyanki*) and domed clay ovens. Archaeological surveys by O. V. Sukhobokov record over 320 Volyntsevo and Romny settlements across the Southern Core, supporting 165k inhabitants by 700AD, 190k by 800AD and 220k by 900AD.

At the same time, the Lower Desna and Dnieper-Sozh corridor became a major artery of Varangian-Rus trade and military organisation [19][20][21]. At Shestovytsia (Korovel, 18 km south-west of Chernigov), excavations by P. Smolychev, D. I. Blifeld, V. P. Kovalenko and O. P. Motsia revealed a 16 ha fortified hillfort and harbour suburb accompanied by five barrow cemeteries (over 400 mounds) containing tenth-century Scandinavian chamber graves with Frankish swords, warhorses, folding balances and Abbasid and Samanid silver dirhams (2,4k inhabitants in 900AD, peaking at 3,2k in 1000AD). In the Chernigov retinue necropolises (Chorna Mohyla, Hulbyshche and Boldyni Hory), B. A. Rybakov's study of the *Chorna Mohyla* princely tumulus (40 m diameter, 11 m height, c. 960AD) and the more than 230 barrows of Boldyni Hory shows that tenth-century Chernigov already functioned as the seat of an autonomous princely and boyar *druzhina* (9,5k inhabitants in 900AD, rising to 18k by 1000AD). Further west, Lyubech (51,7°N, 30,66°E) and Mokhov (52,02°N, 30,73°E) guarded the Dnieper-Sozh-Desna confluence; Lyubech is listed by Constantine Porphyrogenitus (*De Administrando Imperio*, c. 948AD) as *Telioutza*, one of the fortified ship-assembly stations on the route from the Varangians to the Greeks (3,5k at Lyubech and 1,95k at Mokhov in 1000AD).

By 1000AD, following Grand Prince Vladimir Svyatoslavich's integration of the Severian and Radimichi lands (984AD Battle on the Pishchana) and the construction of the Desna-Oster-Sula frontier ramparts (Gorodets Ostersky, Pryluky, Romny and Vovkivtsi), the Southern Core reached 280k inhabitants (3,88 inh/km^2), with an urban population of 37k (13,2%).

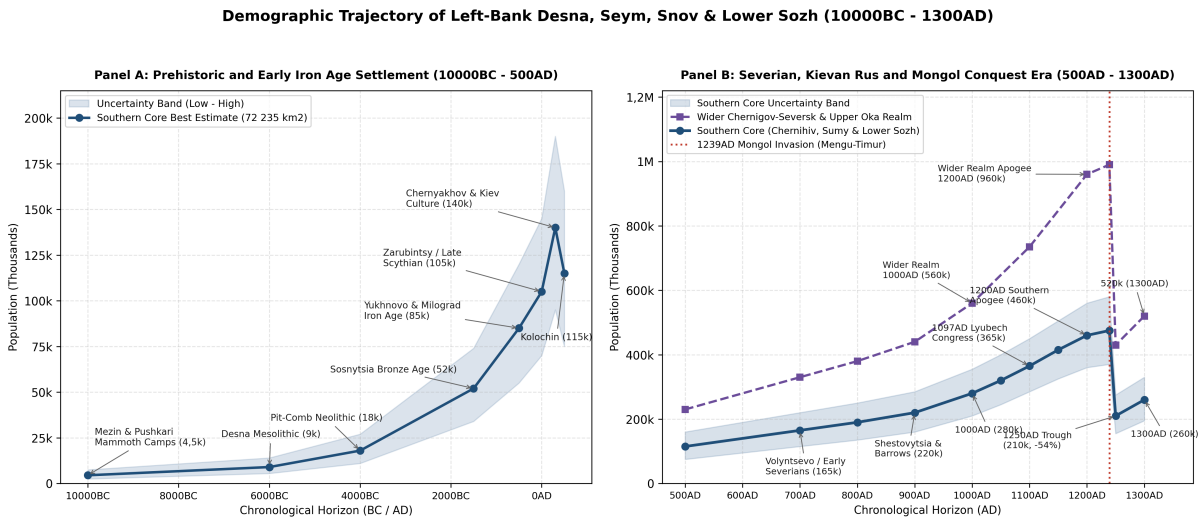


Figure 3. Shaded bands indicate uncertainty ranges around the central estimate for the 72,24k km^2 Southern Core. Pre-Slavic settlement peaked under the Yukhnovo-Milograd hillforts (85k at 500BC) and the Roman-era Kiev and Chernyakhov horizons (140k at 300AD); medieval growth reached 460k in 1200AD before Mengu-Timur's October 1239AD offensive cut the population by more than half to 210k in 1250AD.

The Olgovichi Principalities

Dynastic Consolidation

Following the Battle of Listven (1024AD, fought beside the Listven hillfort 22 km north of Chernigov), Prince Mstislav Vladimirovich established Chernigov as the capital of Left-Bank Rus, founding the stone Transfiguration Cathedral (*Spaso-Preobrazhensky Sobor*, 1030-1036AD) inside the 16 ha *Detinets* [2][19]. Under Svyatoslav Yaroslavich (1054-1076AD) and his son Oleg Svyatoslavich (d. 1115AD), recognised at the Congress of Lyubech (1097AD) as hereditary ruler of the Chernigov-Seversk land, the dynasty promoted internal colonisation across the *Chernigov Opolye*, the middle Desna, the Lower Sozh and the Posemye steppe frontier [1][3].

Archaeological surveys by V. P. Kovalenko [4], A. V. Kuza [6][8], P. P. Tolochko [5], Yu. Yu. Morgunov [22] and H. V. Shtykhov [23] catalogue 116 excavated tenth- to early thirteenth-century fortified *gorodishcha* within the Southern Core (48 in the Chernigov Core, 26 in Novgorod-Seversk, 24 in Putivl-Vorgol-Hlukhiv and 18 in the Lower Sozh and Gomel corridor), plus 78 *gorodishcha* in the northern Russian appanages (194 fortified towns in total across the Grand Principality), surrounded by over 2,1k unfortified rural *selyshcha* (such as the excavated 12 ha rural craft village of Avtunichi).

Major Towns in 1200AD

Following the town density estimates of P. P. Tolochko and A. V. Kuza (120 - 150 inh/ha inside the walled *detinets* and *okolny gorod* ramparts; 75 - 100 inh/ha in the outer *posad* and *podol* craft quarters, or 20 - 25 homesteads per hectare at 5,5 - 6 persons per household), Table 4 sets out the populations of the chief towns in 1200AD and 1250AD.

Urban Centre	Rampart (ha)	Posad (ha)	Total (ha)	1200AD Pop.	1250AD Pop.
Chernigov	160 ha	170 ha	330 ha	35k	5k
Novgorod-Seversk	32 ha	43 ha	75 ha	12k	3,8k
Putivl	22 ha	23 ha	45 ha	7,5k	3,2k
Gomel (Homiy)	18 ha	24 ha	42 ha	5k	2,8k
Hlukhiv	15 ha	17 ha	32 ha	5k	4k
Lyubech	14 ha	16 ha	30 ha	4,5k	2,1k
Vyr	15 ha	20 ha	35 ha	4,5k	800
Romny (Romen)	12 ha	16 ha	28 ha	4,2k	1,5k
Snovsk (Sedniv)	12 ha	12 ha	24 ha	4k	1,2k
Oster	10 ha	12 ha	22 ha	3,5k	1,4k
Pryluky	10 ha	11 ha	21 ha	3,2k	1,1k
Vsevolozh	10 ha	10 ha	20 ha	3k	600
Vorgol	9 ha	11 ha	20 ha	3k	700
Bragin	9 ha	11 ha	20 ha	3k	1,4k
Khorobor	9 ha	9 ha	18 ha	2,8k	900
Unenezh (Nizhyn)	9 ha	9 ha	18 ha	2,8k	950
Sosnytsia	9 ha	9 ha	18 ha	2,8k	1,15k
Rechitsa	8 ha	8 ha	16 ha	2,5k	1,5k
Kursk (Posemye East)	24 ha	31 ha	55 ha	8k	2,2k
Bryansk (Upper Desna)	20 ha	20 ha	40 ha	6k	6,5k
Starodub (Seversk North)	16 ha	18 ha	34 ha	5k	2,4k

Vshchizh (Upper Desna)	14 ha	14 ha	28 ha	4,5k	400

Table 4. Excavated rampart circuits (detinets and okolny gorod), outer craft suburbs (posad and podol) and estimated inhabitants of the 18 chief southern Chernigov-Seversk towns alongside four northern appanage capitals in 1200AD and 1250AD.

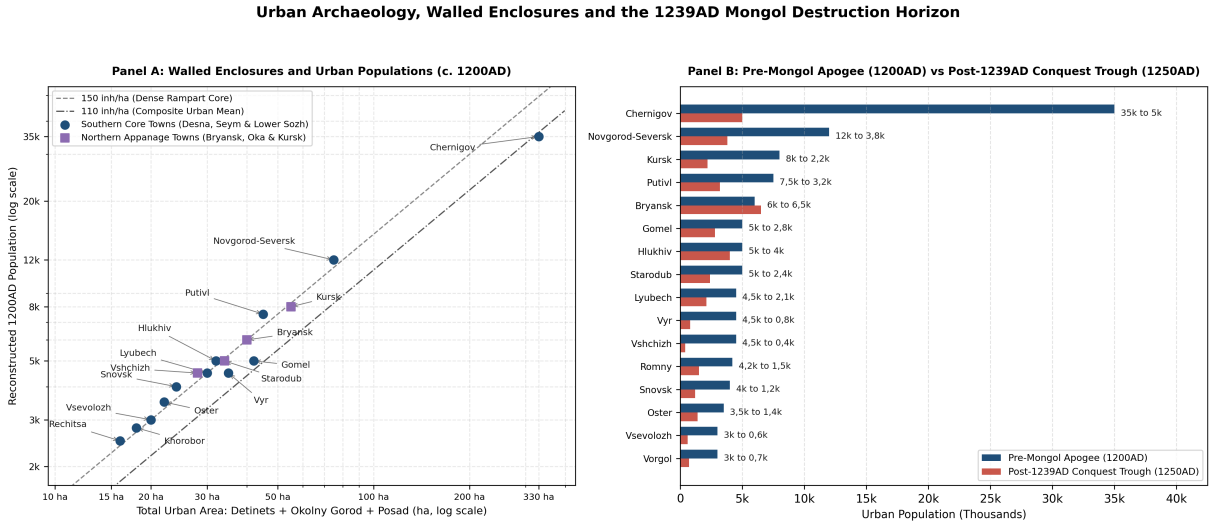


Figure 4. Left: walled rampart and suburban posad areas plotted against urban population in 1200AD, led by the 330 ha capital at Chernigov (35k) and the chalk-bluff citadel of Novgorod-Seversk (75 ha, 12k). Right: the urban collapse between 1200AD and 1250AD across the sacked Desna and Posemye towns compared with the survival of wooded Hlukhiv and the northward growth of Bryansk.

Population by Principality in 1200AD

Across the four southern districts (460k inhabitants in total at 1200AD), the Principality of Chernigov Core accounted for 240k inhabitants. Here settlement centred on the fertile *Chernigov Opolye* between the Desna, Snov and Bilous rivers (12 - 18 inh/km^2), where princely domains (*sela*) such as Orgoshch (2,1k), Listven (1,85k), Blestovit (2k), Gurichev (1,8k), Snovsk (4k) and Berezna (2,2k) supplied grain, warhorses and ironwork to the 35k-strong capital of Chernigov (16 ha *Detinets*, 40 ha *Okolny Gorod*, 20 ha *Tretyak*, 85 ha walled *Peredgorodier* and 170 ha *Podol* and *Leskovitsa* craft suburbs, containing five twelfth- and early thirteenth-century brick cathedrals: the Transfiguration, Boris and Gleb, Dormition at Yeletsky Monastery, St Elias and St Paraskeva Pyatnitsa) [4][19]. Along the Dnieper, middle Desna and Oster-Udai corridors, fortified *volost* centres - Lyubech (4,5k, where B. A. Rybakov excavated the timber-and-earth princely castle of *Zamkova Hora*), Oster (3,5k), Pryluky (3,2k), Vsevolozh (3k), Sosnytsia (2,8k), Khorobor (2,8k), Unenezh (Nizhyn, 2,8k), Baturin (2,6k), Bakhmach (2,4k), Moroviisk (2,2k), Varva (2,1k) and Lutava (1,8k) - supported 68k townspeople (28,3% of the core's population) and 172k rural inhabitants [1].

In the Principality of Novgorod-Seversk along the Middle Desna and Ivot-Esman tributaries (70k inhabitants at 1200AD), administration was conducted from the high chalk headland of Novgorod-Seversk (12k inhabitants across 75 ha, comprising the 2,5 ha *Zamkova Hora* citadel, the 30 ha *Okolny Gorod* and the stone Spaso-Preobrazhensky princely monastery). Celebrated as the seat of Prince Igor Svyatoslavich (1151-1202AD) in the *Tale of Igor's Campaign* (1185AD), this principality controlled the middle Desna

crossings and the wooded Ivot, Znob and Esman valleys, including Voronizh (2,4k), Krolevets-Retezh (1,1k), Znob (950), Shalyhyne-Obesta (850), Ivot (780), Yampil (740) and Kurove-Yukhnovo (720) [3][4].

Across the Principalities of Putivl, Vorgol and Hlukhiv in the Posemye and Upper Sula and Psyol valleys (70k inhabitants at 1200AD), a chain of fortresses guarded the southern forest-steppe frontier against the Polovtsians (*Cumans*). Putivl (7,5k inhabitants across 45 ha, with a twelfth-century brick princely church excavated on *Nikolske Gorka*) stood alongside Vyr (4,5k across 35 ha), Hlukhiv (5k across 32 ha), Romny (4,2k across 28 ha) and Vorgol (3k across 20 ha, seat of an autonomous appanage on the Kleven cliffs between 1203AD and 1241AD) [18][22]. Secondary steppe-watch fortresses along the Seym, Tern, Sula, Psyol and Vorskla included Lipen (Sumy, 2,6k), Okhtyrka (2,5k), Hlinsk (2,3k), Popash (2,2k), Konotop (2,1k), Viakhan (2,1k), Zartyi (1,9k), Lipovets (1,85k), Nedryhailiv (1,35k) and Igoreve Seltsye (1,25k, the fortified princely estate with wine and honey cellars looted in the 1146AD chronicle).

In the Lower Sozh and Dnieper-Braginka Corridor of eastern Gomel (80k inhabitants at 1200AD), which incorporated the southern Radimichi and Dregovichi-Severian contact zone under Chernigov rule, the main river towns were Gomel (*Homiy*, 5k inhabitants across 42 ha, with weapon-smithing workshops excavated by O. A. Makushnykov), Bragin (3k), Rechitsa (2,5k), Chechersk (2,3k), Loyev (2,2k), Khalch (1,45k), Streshin (1,25k), Gorval (1,15k) and Zaspa (1,05k) [23][24].

Mongol Invasion and Post-Conquest Era

Destruction of October 1239AD

In the autumn of 1239AD, following the campaigns against Ryazan (1237AD), Vladimir-Suzdal (1238AD) and Pereyaslavl-Yuzhny (March 1239AD), a Mongol army commanded by Batu's cousin Mengu-Timur (Möngke) and Kadan advanced up the Seym and Desna valleys against the Chernigov-Seversk principalities [3][4]. Archaeological excavations across more than 40 *gorodishcha* in the Southern Core reveal a mid-thirteenth-century destruction layer marked by vitrified timber-and-earth ramparts, clusters of armour-piercing Mongol tanged arrowheads, hoards of silver *grivnas* and temple rings and unburied skeletons in collapsed dwellings and church vaults.

Along the Posemye corridor, Putivl, Vyr, Vorgol, Hlukhiv, Popash and Viakhan were stormed during the autumn offensive along the Seym and Kleven in October 1239AD. At Putivl and Vyr, mass graves containing decapitated and arrow-pierced defenders alongside burned artisan quarters record the loss of the frontier garrisons [18], while Vorgol, Popash, Viakhan and Zartyi suffered destruction and permanent urban abandonment after 1239-1241AD. Along the Desna-Snov-Oster approach, Snovsk, Sosnytsia, Khorobor, Vsevolozh, Unenezh, Orgoshch, Listven and Blestovit were sacked to sever communications before the investment of Chernigov; at Vsevolozh, Blestovit and Unenezh, burned rampart casemates yielded hundreds of skeletons of defenders, women and children who perished in the flames [4].

During the siege and sack of Chernigov on 18 October 1239AD, as recorded in the Laurentian and Hypatian Chronicles, Mongol siege engineers surrounded the city and bombarded the walls with heavy counterweight trebuchets (*poroki*) that hurled stones a distance of a bowshot and a half, each stone requiring four men to lift. Despite a relief sortie led outside the ramparts by Prince Mstislav Glebovich of Rylsk and Chernigov - whose troops were routed in open battle - the Mongols breached the *Okolny Gorod* on 18 October 1239AD, put the city to the torch, looted the five brick cathedrals and slaughtered or enslaved the population [3][4]. Excavations across the 170 ha *Peredgorodier* and *Podol* show that the outer suburbs ceased to be occupied, leaving post-conquest settlement confined to the 16 ha *Detinets* (~5k inhabitants in 1250AD).

Post-Mongol Realignment

Between 1239AD and 1250AD, the population of the Southern Core fell by 54,3%, dropping from 460k (1200AD) to 210k (1250AD, 2,91 inh/km^2), while the urban share declined from 21,5% to 10,5%. Over 65% of the 116 fortified *gorodishcha* in the Southern Core ceased to function as urban settlements. Following the execution of Grand Prince Mikhail Vsevolodovich of Chernigov and his boyar Fedor at the Golden Horde in September 1246AD for refusing to walk between purification fires [3], the political and settlement geography of the Chernigov-Seversk lands underwent a three-way realignment between 1246AD and 1300AD.

Under Mikhail's younger son Roman Mikhailovich the Old (1246-1288AD), the senior princely seat moved from Chernigov northward into the forests of Bryansk, which grew from 6k (1200AD) to 6,5k (1250AD). Even so, Chernigov, Lyubech (2,5k in 1300AD) and the Lower Sozh towns (Gomel at 3,4k, Rechitsa at 1,9k, Bragin at 1,75k and Chechersk at 1,65k) retained a reduced episcopal and princely administration, supporting 130k inhabitants in the Chernigov Core and 50k in the Lower Sozh by 1300AD [24][25].

In 1247AD, Mikhail Vsevolodovich's second son Simeon Mikhailovich established an autonomous hereditary principality at Hlukhiv (1247-1408AD) on the wooded Esman-Kleven plateau (51,68°N, 33,92°E). Sheltered by marshy forests north of the steppe corridor, Hlukhiv retained 4k inhabitants in 1250AD and 4,5k in 1300AD, serving as the main urban refuge in the southern Seversk lands until the mid-fourteenth century.

Meanwhile, descendants of the Igorichi line maintained the Principality of Putivl (3,2k inhabitants in 1250AD, recovering to 3,8k by 1300AD) alongside Novgorod-Seversk (3,8k in 1250AD, 4,5k in 1300AD) and Romny (1,95k in 1300AD). Under Golden Horde suzerainty, the Posemye was supervised by the Mongol *baskak* Akhmad, whose creation of tax-exempt *slobody* near Lipovets and Vorgol provoked the 1283-1285AD uprising of Princes Oleg of Rylsk-Vorgol and Svyatoslav of Lipovets recorded in the Laurentian Chronicle [18][25]. By 1300AD, natural recovery across these wooded riverine valleys restored the Southern Core to 260k inhabitants (3,6 inh/km^2), while the wider Chernigov-Seversk realm (including the northern Russian appanages) stood at 520k inhabitants.

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